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TRANSPORTATION



Tesla vet says that
'reviewing real products'
— not mock-ups — is the
key to staying innovative

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- The uproar over Vogue's AI-generated ad isn't just about fashion

“But one night, Elon got lucky and said, ‘Steve, if you had one piece of advice for me as a young entrepreneur’ — he had just done PayPal and was joining the team at Tesla — ‘what would that be?’ Steve said, ‘Elon, you’re now in the hardware business, but the hardware business is a lot like the software business. If you want to be successful in business, you have to get one thing right, and that is, you have to have a perfect product. And if the product is beautiful, it will sell itself.’”

- Your public ChatGPT queries are getting indexed by Google and other search engines
- The best dating apps aren’t even dating apps

TE

Tech and VC heavyweights join the Disrupt 2025 agenda

Netflix, Eleven Labs, Weave, Sequoia

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Musk took that to heart, McNeill said, and the concept of a perfect product became central to product development at Tesla.

“The thing we were looking for first of all was surprise and delight. Like, are we doing something that is going to just make somebody go wow or laugh or have fun?

“Crazy example of that is the fart button,” McNeill said, referring to a software button labeled

“Emissions Testing Mode” that would simulate flatulence through the car’s speakers.

The company also prized minimalism, which on the software side meant keeping functions accessible in fewer than two taps on the screen.

“It has to be a kind of a no-brainer for the average user. Then we would double back the designer — the lead designer was always in the room — and then we would say, OK, Franz, now make it beautiful.”

Meetings like those, where the actual product was reviewed, not a mock-up, helped preserve Tesla’s

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“One of the things I’m most proud of is Mary Barra, CEO, and Mark Reuss, president, [who oversee] a 275,000 person, \$200 billion revenue company, are running product reviews every week where there’s no slides. You’ve got to see the real product [whether it’s] hardware, software. If it’s hardware, it’s in the room. You’re touching it. You’re feeling it,” he said.

“That stuff is so powerful. And it’s led to GMs introduction of 17 EVs, now the second best selling EVs in the country. Because they’re just on product, every week.”



Tim De Chant

Senior Reporter, Climate | [X](#) [🦋](#) [in](#)

Tim De Chant is a senior climate reporter at TechCrunch. He has written for a wide range of publications, including...

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The future of the car is not about propulsion

Mike Hoefflinger — 4:00 PM PDT · April 9, 2016

I'm impatient to see breakthroughs in cars. I have high expectations for what Apple will do and respect for what Tesla has already done. I agree with Peter Thiel on the we-were-promised-jet-cars-but-got-140-characters thing, and with Larry Page, who worries that Silicon Valley doesn't throw the ball down the field enough.

So, with all the talk of the Chevy Bolt Tesla-killer, the will-they-or-won't-they joint venture of Google and Ford, the Tesla Model 3 March unveil, the intrigue around Apple Car, GM's unicorn acquisition of the 40-person self-driving car-kit maker Cruise Automation and \$4 billion of federal monies for self-driving cars, it's a great time to take stock.

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this showdown for the Model 3, it will finally be time for him to compete in the brutal business of \$30,000 cars with someone who's been to that end-zone before (Mary Barra and GM) and figure out how he will create demand for 10x as many vehicles per year as he sold in 2015.

Apple: By 2019 (and possibly 2020 if the issues with the internal Jony Ive review this January cause delays), Tim Cook will be three years behind Mary (and two behind Elon). While that's not been a fundamental problem for Apple in the past, he'll need to ship a v1.0 of Apple Car that's more like v1.0 of iPhone than v1.0 of Apple Watch.

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Google: To be honest, after the non-announcement announcements and non-denial denials, I'm confused about whether they're building cars with Amazon or with Ford. Or both. Or neither. In the meantime, they've driven the most autonomous miles of anyone. By far.

All the electrics are screwed

Then it hit me: At sub-\$30 oil (a quarter of 2008 levels), they're all screwed.

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\$2-per-gallon gas is so toxic to (at least U.S.) electric vehicle demand that sales in 2015 actually

went down year-over-year (to say nothing of their utterly anemic 1.4 percent share of the market).

As gas prices eased, America's consumers returned to buying Dodge RAM trucks with the 6.4L HEMI V8 (which is why Chrysler is crushing it). Turns out Mary's surprise victory, all of Elon's hard work, those 100 acres Tim bought in San Jose so he can cover the eyes and drive a drive truck.

Sigh.

It's not

But, wait, the same

However

about metal, drive-trains or batteries (or even particular autonomous systems). It will be about the experience inside.

For all but the car enthusiast, a car is not about the car. Or even about the act of driving. It is about getting somewhere in a way that does not suck. If Uber's meteoric rise has taught us anything, it's

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It will be
experience in which we will eventually consider things like windshields without wall-to-wall integrated transparent displays for information and entertainment as anachronistic as physical keyboards on our phones (don't scoff, your windshield is smaller than a 65" TV, 4K versions of which are already down to \$1,500 today, and millimeter-thin transparent displays of that size have already been shown by LG, Panasonic and Samsung), and wonder where mixed reality glasses have been all our lives.

That — pardon the terrible category name — is a smart car.

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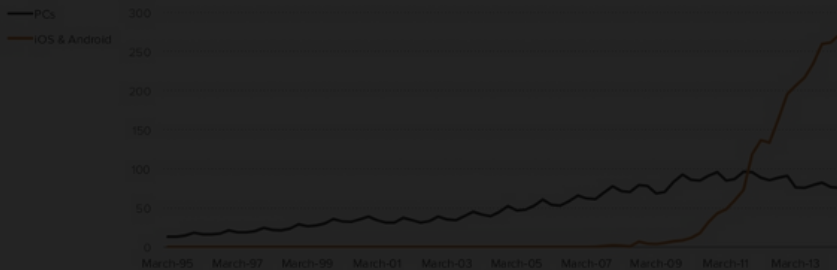
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A second look at the competition

The smartphone industry dwarfs PCs

4bn people buying every 2 years instead of 1.6bn buying every 5 years

Quarterly unit shipments (m)



Source: Gartner, Apple, Google, eStat

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Not wholesale displacement (e.g. Nokia, Blackberry, Motorola), but a negative impact in desirable and profitable segments similar to what happened to PCs, which are predicted to stabilize at 32 percent lower volume than their 2011 peaks. That could mean millions of vehicles less annually for incumbents.

In the context of that shift, here's another look at the players:

GM (and other OEM incumbents): Look at the interfaces inside your car. Do you love them?

Turning the rearview mirror in the Bolt into a screen that shows the rear-facing camera is a nice touch, but the incumbents are bringing butter knives to an interface railgun fight in the segments of the market that will be driven by cabin experience. Low-end, trucks and performance will be spared, but the luxury badges need to watch out.

Apple CarPlay and Android Auto: Can the incumbents save themselves by turning a screen over to the apps we know? I've used Apple CarPlay and it's a sad-face shadow of an Apple experience. Not quite Motorola ROKR bad, but not the winning move.

Google's smartp
autonom
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succes

Tesla: TI
country
biggest

Apple C
Never tangle with a Sicilian when death is on the line. And never, ever get into a user experience battle with the hardware/software integration — not to mention velvet handcuff ecosystem — of Apple. While they admittedly appear to be missing other large pieces of the smart car puzzle, including manufacturing, autonomous systems and retail and service, you simply cannot bet against them with three-ish years to go and Tim Cook seemingly ready to play Santa Claus.

In the lucrative segments, Apple wins. Google supplies the rest — although a few will try to roll their own.

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Mike Hoefflinger

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Vocal Tesla short seller has reversed course, driving shares higher

Kirsten Korosec — 1:50 PM PDT · October 23, 2018

Citron Research, an influential short-seller that has been a staunch critic of Tesla, reversed its position on the electric automaker. The about-face, which Citron Research outlined in a research note Tuesday, helped pushed Tesla shares up 12.7 percent to close at \$294.14.

The research note, entitled, “Citron reverses opinion on Tesla. The story has become too compelling to ignore,” explains that it has taken a long position in Tesla because “the Model 3 is a proven hit and many of the TSLA warning signs have proven not to be significant.”

Investors who take short positions on a stock are

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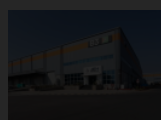
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Federal regulators give Zoox an exemption for its custom-built robotaxis

Kirsten Korosec - 13 hours ago

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Jeh Aerospace nets \$11M to scale the commercial aircraft supply chain in India

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its thinking.

“Tesla appears to be the only company that can actually produce and sell electric cars,” according to note. “If you would have shown us the below chart five years ago there is no way we would have ever believed it. It looks like it is the competition that is taking the Ambien.” (CEO Elon Musk has tweeted about taking Ambien.)

A tweet from Citron Research early Tuesday also warned that Tesla’s decision to report earnings Wednesday “might be a bad sign for shorts.”



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Even with Musk's [alleged](#) [bearing](#) for alleged Musk's [indefinite going private tweet](#) in August.

Tesla has faced notable headwinds, including a volatile stock price, "[production hell](#)" and later, logistics/delivery hell with the Model 3, as well as a [securities fraud complaint](#) and [subsequent settlement agreement](#) between CEO Elon Musk and the U.S. Securities and Exchange Commission. There has been a steady stream of high-level executive departures and questions about worker safety in its factory.

At the same time, Tesla still has very few competitors, if you look at comparable price and battery range. And sales continue to rise, indicating

that all the drama around Tesla hasn't impacted demand.

The [Chevy Bolt](#), an all-electric hatchback that gets an EPA estimated 238 miles to a single charge, went on sale in late 2016. And while it was the first all-electric EV priced under \$50,000 capable of delivering an EPA-rated range over 200 miles, sales plateaued and are down 17 percent since the beginning of 2018, GM reported in early October.

Jaguar is the newest all-electric luxury category competitor with the introduction of the [I-Pace](#), which has a base price of \$69,500 and an EPA estimated range of 234 miles. The first I-Pace

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Kirsten Korosec is a reporter and editor who has covered the future of transportation from EVs and autonomous...

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